

IT CORRIDOR

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Neelankarai » Sholinganallur » Thiruvannamiyur » Vijaya Nagar » Indira Nagar » Karapakkam » Kotturpuram » Padur » Thalambur » Pallikarai



OVERFLOWING SEWAGE, RESIDENTS ASK PERMANENT SOLUTION

At Bharathi Nagar in Guindy, uneven level of the manhole and collection well is raising a stink **P3**



A DUBIOUS RARITY

At Mudichur, birders chanced upon a Java sparrow while having gone there in the hope of seeing another bird species, a passage migrant in and around Chennai. The Java sparrow is a breeding resident in parts of Indonesia **P6**

READERS WRITE

'Spruce up area outside Youth Hostel in Adyar'

S. GANAPATHI SANKARAN

Residents of Indira Nagar Second Avenue Service Lane in Adyar are living amidst an uneasy atmosphere.

Along Indira Nagar Second Avenue, there are three bus shelters. The area along the stop for buses towards Thiruvannamalai, below a banyan tree, is used for cooking, the garbage left

behind attracts stray dogs and cattle. The area behind Metropolitan Transport Corporation bus shelters and the service lane is misused. Those waiting to board buses towards Thiruvannamalai and Trichy, urinate and defecate behind the bus shelters and between the abandoned vehicles parked along the service lane, creating an unhealthy atmosphere. On days leading up to 'Pradosham', 'Shivarathri' and 'Pour-



nami', people going to Thiruvannamalai to do 'Girivalam' park their vehicles on the lane and return

after two days. The residents find it difficult to reverse and take their vehicles out.

As a row of buses are

parked on Avenue Road, honking by drivers adds to the noise pollution. The halt should be shifted to the spacious premises of the Gandhi Nagar bus terminus at Adyar on Sardar Patel Road as the terminus has a wash-room. Behind the shelters, trash and vehicles are dumped and parked, including abandoned vehicles with dust on them. Though the shelters are well-lit, the overgrown tree branches and the

area around the vehicles make it a perfect spot for youngsters to engage in anti-social activities.

Mechanics have observed tilting vehicles, causing oil and grease to spill onto the road surface along the stormwater drain network pits. This practice has resulted in hazardous, slippery conditions, leading to incidents where individuals have slipped and fallen.

Additionally, vehicles are being parked on the stormwater drain network. A face-lift to the area outside the Youth Hostel will be good.

S. Ganapathi Sankaran is a resident of Indira Nagar



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A **persistent odour** in Pudhupakkam

Residents urge the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board to inspect the factories



Representational picture only. PHOTO: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of the Pudhupakkam region have requested the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board to inspect industries in the region and adjoining areas. The re-

quest comes in the wake of a persistent foul smell hanging in the air in the area. Residents have been complaining about it for some time now.

A. Devananth, founder, Jasraj Nagar and Sai Baba Nagar Residents' Welfare Association, says, "Every day, around 5.30 p.m., a

stench fills the air that continues till 10 p.m. We have to close the windows and lock the doors."

Pudhupakkam, Kelambakkam and the adjoining OMR have a number of industries, including dyeing, tannery, apparels and pharmaceuticals. SIDCO Pharmaceutical Industrial Estate is located

more than 10 km from the region. Residents suspect the smell could be from the industries.

Some say the smell is heavy towards the Pudhupakkam junction. A resident raised this issue with TNPCB more than three weeks ago, but no action has been taken.

IIT Madras to advance technologies in battery circularity

Bridge Green Upcycle, a pioneer in lithium-ion battery circularity and critical mineral recovery, has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Indian Institute of Technology - Madras to develop advanced technologies for the future of critical minerals.

Professor V. Kamakoti, director, IIT Madras, and Balki Iyer, founder and chairman of Bridge Green, exchanged the MoU during SustainX 2026, the IIT Madras's flagship sustainability conference.

The two will work towards transforming waste into valuable resources for the future by combining advanced materials science, and process innovation, the release added.

Inter-school oratorical competition

Union Christian Matriculation Higher Secondary School, Chetpet will be conducting the second edition of its inter-school oratorical competition, Oratoria'26, for students of classes VII to XII on October 29 and 30. The event would also feature a debate segment with an overall prize package worth ₹90,000 including a return ticket to an exotic destination, said a release. Scan the QR code to register. Contact: 73051 75551/97892 91683



Recycling all that clay

Here are ways to reuse the clay from Ganesh Chaturthi idols that have been left behind

MALINI KALAYANAM

Local garden nurseries are encouraged to use the clay from Ganesh Chaturthi idols that vendors have left behind. They can recycle this clay and make it saleable again by adding to it ingredients such as hay, saw dust, broken-down barks of trees, shredded paper, cocopeat, sugarcane molasses, mushroom molasses, perlite or sand, vegetable kitchen waste, garden soil and cow dung to make it suitable for the growth of saplings. This process of addition would make it a rich compost.

Creating immense value from anything that is discarded is highly appreciated and prevents the landfills from getting overburdened.

Business opportunities extend by routing this into different pathways suitable for different kinds of

plants with composition changes in the ingredients' mix.

Instead of dumping the clay in waterbodies, we must ensure the clay is either reused by potters or reused by potential garden enthusiasts or local garden nurseries.

Clay contains nutrients and minerals that can help plants when combined with other ingredients as a mix. People are dissuaded from purchasing painted Ganeshas moving forward, as this is not suitable for plants and can be hazardous as paints contain chemicals. Even if it is being reused by potters, they find it difficult for reuse as paints are hazardous and can create allergic reactions.

It is people who create the demand. Be a responsible and informed buyer.

When one stops buying painted or coloured Ganeshas, their supply diminishes automatically. Sell-



At a workshop.

ers buy their supply based on the market demand.

Do not give room for Plaster of Paris idols either as they are painted and cannot be dissolved in water after Visarjan.

Celebrating the Ganesha festival and maintaining the tradition and culture with reverence is im-

portant but celebrating it responsibly is the need of the hour.

(Malini Kalyanam, a social activist and environmentalist, is director of Artistic Pottery Training Academy in Kattupakkam, and founder trustee, The PALM, a public charitable trust that empowers women)

Season two of Battle of Brains

Battle of Brains, an inter-school quiz, is back with its second season. Organised by Casagrand, in association with Nexus Consulting, schools across Chennai can register teams of two students from classes 6 to 10 at no cost. Registrations are open until October 5, 2026.

The event will be held from October 10 to November 15, 2026.

The winning teams from the zonal rounds will advance to the city final, where they will compete for the Battle of Brains Season 2 title.

The second season will also extend the quizzing experience beyond students with a dedicated parents and teachers quiz.

Overflowing sewage: residents want permanent solution

At Bharathi Nagar in Guindy, the condition of a collection well is a huge cause for concern

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of Bharathi Nagar in Guindy have requested the Adyar zone of Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board (CMWSSB) to level the manhole and collection well at the Board's sewage pumping station on Tank Street.

S. Narayanan, a long-time resident of Guindy and a social activist, says, "Sewage from homes on Pillayar Koil Street, Ambedkar Street, Nethaji Street, Krishnamoorthy Street, MGR Street, Bharathi Street, and Tank Street in the locality drains into the manhole, but it is unable to enter the collection well because of its elevated position."

As a result, sewage overflows from the manhole on Tank Street, making life difficult for pedestrians and motorists.

Every time we have to call the helpline number to pump the water from the manhole and from the street. Though the workers do clean, the problem re-surfaces, the sewage flows on the stretch, creating a breeding ground for mosquitoes and a health hazard for residents of Tank Street and Thiruvalluvar Street in Race View Colony, say residents.

Hundreds of bus and train commuters take this stretch, and the sight of overflowing sewage presents a dirty picture.

S. Evangeline, a senior citizen and a resident of Guindy, says, "The lighting is poor on the stretch after sunset, some use the torchlight on their phones to not step on the sewage. We have requested CMWSSB to level the manhole and the collection well infrastructure, but no action has been taken to date."



A COMMON SIGHT AT TANK STREET. THIS IMAGE WAS TAKEN ON SEPTEMBER 23, 2026. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Hindustan University brings student-athletes for volleyball and football tourney

This annual event is being conducted since 2019 to honour the vision of Elizabeth Verghese, Founder Chancellor

More than 450 student-athletes across 15 universities and institutions took part in the 'Founder Chancellor Trophy 2026' organised by the Department of Physical Education and Sports Sciences at Hindustan Institute of Technology and Science at its Padur campus.

The participant line-up included 252 men's football players, 135 men's volleyball players, and 72 women's volleyball players. Organised annually since 2019, the Founder Chancellor Trophy honours the vision of Elizabeth Verghese, Founder Chancellor, reflecting the institution's com-

mitment to fostering sportsmanship, youth development, teamwork, and excellence, said a release. The tournament, held from September 21 to 23, was inaugurated in the presence of Vice-Chancellor Vikas Misra and Registrar Dr. S.S.Rao.

Former International Volleyball Player and South Asian Games Gold Medallist A. Sivaraman attended as the chief guest, alongside Ganesh Prabhu, an alumnus of HITS and Global Head of Strategic Partnerships at Aspin Holdings LLC Dubai. The dignitaries presented championship trophies, medals, and cash prizes to

talling ₹1.5 lakh to the winning teams, added the release.

Tournament winners

Men's Football: Champions - SRM Institute of Science & Technology (SRM IST), Chennai

Men's Volleyball: Champions - SRM Institute of Science & Technology (SRM IST), Chennai

Women's Volleyball: Champions - Vels University

Runners-Up & other Finishes: Tamil Nadu Physical Education and Sports University (TNPESU), Vinayaka Mission's Research Foundation (Chennai Campus), and host teams from Hindustan University.

The winning volleyball teams from SRM Institute of Science & Technology and Vels University



Old Markets, New Trends is a column that features markets that have continued to retain their hold on people's mindscape despite the shifting sands of fads. Through entities that have been around for a long time, it seeks to find out what makes these markets tick

Tarpaulin is just the 'trailer'

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Umbrellas are a victim of "folk association". They are certainly not the sole preserve of the monsoon with its drippy skies, but that is the period they get busier and therefore, get almost entirely associated with the rains. The tarpaulin shops at Nehru Market on Sydenhams Road in Periamet are busy through the year and get a tad busier when the monsoon is round the corner.

But one peek into these tarpaulin shops and there is not a shred of doubt about their all-year relevance. And now, tarpaulin seems like a generic term for a whole range of products that offer a protective cover to valuables. These shops sell those green shade nets for gardens, tents for camping, cotton canvas covers, car covers and bags (which are also covers, glorified covers). These bags are not high-fashion, but made of heavy-duty material and designed to last.

Tarpaulins of various thickness and materials, both determining their prices, are a dominant presence, but one can always shop for more than tarpaulins.

At Nehru Market, there is more to the tarpaulin shops than their name suggests. Their range includes camp tents for the outdoor-oriented and shade nets for those with a green thumb. With the NE monsoon (when they are a tad busier) just weeks away, a look at what helps them cope with changing buyer behaviour



Tarpaulin shops at Nehru Market. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nehru Market is next door to Anna Market, which is dominated by sale of metal items, many of them massive spare parts that go into the running of industrial machinery. The first few shops at Nehru Market are tarpaulin shops, wholesale and retail, but step in-

side and the shops selling spare parts for industrial machinery predominate. These two markets are not next door neighbours but closer than that, as united as two intercommunicating rooms with a common door. The tarpaulin shops and those selling used spare parts for

industrial machinery exist side by side, by design.

Anil Kumar of Prakash Trading Company points out that these tarpaulin covers are used to cover machinery, among other things. While out here to purchase metal parts for heavy-duty industrial machinery, someone might pick up tarpaulins too. These shops also draw adventurers who like to camp out in a temporary shelter under the skies. Similarly, those with a green thumb. The green shade nets are for them.

Anil Kumar notes that almost every shop, the wholesale shops for certain, would have a tailor attached to it. The tents, shade nets and cotton canvas have to be made to order, often. Promptness is a key factor driving success and survival in this business.

Many of these tarpaulin shops are carryovers from a different era, one pithily defined as "Moore Market". Following the Moore Market fire in the 1980s, traders fanned out depending on where they were allocated a space. That is how some

of the tarpaulin sellers ended up in Nehru Market, managed by Greater Chennai Corporation.

Anil Kumar shoulders the weight of a legacy: the shop was established by his father Narayan Jha over 50 years ago. He worked alongside his father and brother before their deaths, and now the weight of that legacy is entirely on his shoulders. And he finds it to be excruciatingly heavy not only due to the lack of support from a kindred soul, but also market realities. "Counter sales has dwindled," says Anil. "Demand has generally fallen with online shopping changing the way customers buy."

So this is where it stands: much of the regular business comes from factories that use the material to cover machinery, as well as from transporters. Anil qualifies that, saying there is still demand for shade nets, tents, car covers and other items but there is huge competition from various quarters.

The promise of getting items at wholesale rates or even purse-friendly retail rates continues to hold out an attraction for the cost-conscious, and they hit Nehru market. Another shop seller, who does not want to be named, points out that tarpaulins, camping tents and car covers are available at wholesale prices on a section of Walltax Road, largely Ramanan Road and near Elephant Gate Street. But Nehru Market in Sydenhams Road scores on ease of access.

LIFFY THOMAS

More than 11,500 kilos of abandoned, lost or discarded fishing nets, known as ghost nets, were collected in the last three months from the Chennai coast, largely from the Neelankarai-to-Kovalam section. That is just the tip of the iceberg. Tonnes of them are yet to be retrieved from our long coastline, many entangled around marine animals preventing them from moving freely.

“In fact, when the North East Monsoon sets in, the quantity of ghost nets being collected also increases depending on the wind pattern seen during the months of October to March. From December onwards, the ghost nets are observed floating closer to the shore,” says Supraja Dharani, founder of TREE Foundation, a Chennai-based non-governmental organisation that focuses on marine conservation.

Since 2021, the Foundation has been playing a key role in removing tonnes of ghost nets by empowering different stakeholders attached to the seas, the local community and the fishers being their chief ambassadors.

As part of capacity building programmes, they conduct workshops to train fishers in identifying and retrieving a net by steering their boats towards it, looking for marine species in the net, releasing it and pulling the net closer to the boat and bringing it to the shores where it is weighed and sent for recycling.

Tree Foundation currently works in the Chennai-Chengalpattu stretch of the coast, many parts of Andhra Pradesh starting from Sullurpeta, Bapatla, Prakasham, Godavari, Vizianagaram and Srikakulam, southern Odisha and western Goa.

Sea Turtle Protection Force

“Our work in retrieving ghost nets extends to more than 800 km, 285 fishing villages, and 411 fishing



Fishing for ghost nets

Through its Sea Turtle Protection Force, TREE Foundation has built an army of fishers who retrieve ghost nets from the sea



An awareness programme by TREE Foundation for fishermen about ghost nets; and (above) fishermen retrieve abandoned nets.

community members who are part of the Sea Turtle Protection Force; they are the point of contact for fishers of the respective villages,”

says Supraja.

One of the biggest motivations for fishers to retrieve ghost nets is the incentive they receive for the

quantity they collect.

The amount of payment depends on the weight of the net. “Fifty percent of the amount goes to their bank account and the rest to the wife’s or mother’s account, which is used for children’s education, repair of nets and medical emergencies,” says the marine activist.

In the last five years, 217 tonnes of ghost nets have been handed to the TREE Foundation. To further felicitate those who have removed the maximum quantity of ghost nets, a felicitation event is held, usually in the first week of October, where other stakeholders including officers from the Coast Guard and Fisheries department are invited.

“Our success is the result of awareness programmes that we conduct teaching the fisherman how to release entangled endangered marine life including turtles, retrieve the ghost net and hand it over to TREE Foundation. Till date 974 marine megafauna have been released by the fishermen all recorded by videos or photos,” she

says.

The abandoned nets are weighed and sent for recycling. The Foundation has made a pathway at its biodiversity centre in Marakkanam.

Finding corporates willing to support the programme financially is a challenge, and Supraja says they are grateful to be supported by Royal Enfield and AstraZeneca in the ghost net retrieval and incentivisation programme for fishermen along Chengalpattu and Chennai coast.

The weight of these nets range from 100 to 700 kilos and tying it to their boats and bringing it to the shore is not easy.

“We want more corporates to support us in other coastal areas as well. We are soon going to set up a small unit where the nets will be shredded and made into small tiles,” she says. More support from corporates would mean getting more fishermen to join the diving team.

Removing ghost nets entangled in coral reefs will also be an extension of Foundation’s work.

Extending from coast to coast

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

If you are a certified diver then HCL Foundation, the CSR arm of HCL Technologies, should be happy to engage your service to scour the ocean depths for ghost nets. Under HCL Harit, the Foundation has been playing a key role in removing ghost nets.

Started in 2022 from the Chennai coast in Neelankarai, today the initiative extends along the Gulf of Mannar, coasts along Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Odisha.

As per data, they have successfully mapped, retrieved, and repurposed nearly 4 lakh plus kilograms of abandoned, lost or discarded fishing gear (ALDFG), across several distinct coastal locations in India.

In the Gulf of Mannar, more than 12.9 metric tons of ghost nets have been removed from ecologically sensitive habitats surrounding 21 islands. In Kundapura, Karnataka, they have launched an innovative buy-back model that incentivises fishers to return dis-

carded nets, helping recover over 10,000 kg of ghost gear.

Nidhi Pundhir, vice-president - Global CSR, HCL Tech and Director, HCL Foundation, says they have a MoU with the Ministry of Environment, and over the years they have built a nationwide coalition involving scientific institutions, diving teams, fisher communities, the Indian Coast Guard, coastal police, and grassroot organisations to tackle marine debris.

A dedicated ghost gear man-

agement component was integrated into the Fisher Friend Mobile Application, enabling real time tracking and reporting of ghost gear by fishing communities.

Nidhi says there is a whole process involved in recycling the ghost nets that serves as a supplementary income for communities. “When we get these nets, they have a whole lot of salt coating on it and is not easily recyclable. We are doing a lot of R&D including converting them into nets which are used for various sports activities, designing bags and for other creative use,” says Nidhi.

To engage university students

to design upcycled, functional products from the retrieved nylons, the Foundation conducted the Ghost Net Innovation Challenge. Recently, on International Coastal Cleanup Day, the Foundation organised a mega cleanup campaign of oceans, involving volunteer and community members.

“From CSR design point of view, we have been thinking that we really need to take a district-level kind of an approach in certain places where we have higher employee strength. And we have been looking at a “convergence model” as our next step,” says Nidhi.

At Mudichur, birders chanced upon a Java sparrow while having gone there in the hope of seeing another bird species. The Java sparrow is a breeding resident in parts of Indonesia. And this particular individual is likely a captive bird that had slipped out of a cage, raising questions about the sordid side of the pet trade

PRINCE FREDERICK

The backdrop can sometimes cast a sombre shadow over a stage pulsating with a grand achievement. Knowing the backstory can automatically signal restraint, cutting out celebration, even justified celebration, without a twinge of regret. An extensively reported event this year would make this idea clearer. Royal Challengers Bangalore cut out the victory parade following their triumph in IPL 2026 clearly because the “backdrop” of a tragic stampede the previous year loomed large casting a long shadow over a merry moment that played out on a grand stage. Something parallel to that, sans the sombreness, happened recently in the Chennai Metropolitan Area.

Over a week’s duration, the start date being September 19, Mudichur in Tambaram witnessed a parade of birders out to catch a glimpse of a rare avian, so rare that when news of its sighting hit their “auriculars”, some dropped their telephoto zoom lens. It was a Java sparrow (*Padda oryzivora*) found in parts of Indonesia, Java being one of them, where they are meant to be found. The sad story (actually, the backstory birders out here were aware of) is that this bird is also found where it has no business poking its beak around, and it is not to be blamed for that. Aviculture and, in a larger sense, human beings’ innate ability honed by greed to interfere with Nature’s delicate but sound systems. The birders sensed this bird could have slipped past the open shutter of some cage



Java sparrow and (above) European roller at Mudichur on September 19. PHOTOS: JITHESH BABU

here, and that knowledge tempered the sense of having found something rare. They clicked away still, but there was restraint in their posts about the sighting.

Birders Jithesh Babu and Saravana Manian had discovered the Java sparrow in Mudichur serendipitously while seeking to pay another bird a visit, a passage migrant in Chennai.

“On September 19, we were there looking for the European roller, which was reported to have been sighted at Mudichur,” says Jithesh. The European roller (*Coracias garululus*) not showing up immediately, the birders ventured a little further in than they had expected to, and

there it was, a surprise in a package of red, pink, grey, black and white: a Java sparrow with, probably until recently, a local address on its calling card.

If the European roller had a sense of humour and the power of speech to express it, it surely would have rasped out “and you thought I was the surprise!” The European roller breeds in Europe and winters in Africa and is known to ink in Chennai as a pit stop on its iconic long-distance migration, almost treated as a sub category in migration, being dubbed “roller migration”. Last year, European roller sighting was reported from the Broken Bridge area of the Adyar Estuary.

VELS University honours 1,000 school teachers



VELS University organised the VELS Teachers Excellence Awards 2026 across its various campuses. As part of the Teachers' Day celebrations, the felicitation ceremony was held at the VELS University campus in Pallavaram. Premalatha Vijayakant, MLA, Virudhachalam Constituency and general secretary, DMDK, graced the occasion as chief guest and felicitated the teachers, says a press release.

Preethaa Ganesh, vice president, VELS University, said that "teaching is the finest profession, as it creates and shapes all other professions."

Premalatha Vijayakant recalled the teacher who had a significant influence on her during her school years. She said: "Teachers carry the great responsibility of guiding students on the right path. Captain



▼ Premalatha Vijayakant with the awardees

own life as well. A teacher named Loganathan guided me and played an important role in shaping me into the person I am today. Though he is no longer with us, I will always remember and acknowledge his contribution to all my achievements."

The VELS Teachers Excellence Awards 2026 have been instituted to recognise and honour the dedicated service of teachers who play a significant role in shaping students' knowledge, skills, character and future, says the press release.

The event was attended by Arthi Ganesh, pro chancellor, VELS University; M. Baskaran, vice chancellor; M. Chandrasekaran, registrar, and other senior members of the university administration.

Vijayakant deeply understood the importance of education and extended educational assistance to thousands of students to help them continue their studies. Behind the success of every student, there is the contribution of a teacher who guided and encouraged them. There was such a teacher in my

K Mohandas Memorial Award for former Tamil Nadu DGP



K Ramanujam, former Director General of Police, Tamil Nadu, receives the award.

B Force, a charitable trust based in Chennai, operating with the aim of providing and facilitating the Tamil Nadu Police force and their families with medical assistance, specifically in the areas of management of cancer, was launched as a tribute to K. Mohandas IPS, former Director General of Police, Tamil Nadu and his wife, Santha Mohandas. K. Mohandas belonged to the 1956 batch of the Indian Police Service, Tamil Nadu cadre. The trust was established by the four daughters of the Mohandas couple.

A press release from B Force points out that to commemorate

its anniversary, B Force bestows an award instituted as "The K Mohandas Memorial Award". This award is conferred upon a past senior police officer who has contributed to the police force beyond the call of his duty.

This year, on September 22, 2026, to commemorate its 19th anniversary, B Force conducted an awards ceremony at Amir Mahal. Recipient of the prestigious award is K Ramanujam IPS, former Director General of Police, Tamil Nadu. As chief guest, Nawabzada Mohammed Asif Ali, Dewan to the Prince of Arcot presented and felicitated the decorated officer with the award.

135 school teachers in the limelight at Guru Dhakshina 2026



Agurchand Manmull Jain College, recently hosted its much-anticipated annual ceremony, Guru Dhakshina 2026, a celebration of gratitude recognising teachers at the Bhagwan Mahaveer Gyan Bhavan.

The college paid tribute to 135 school teachers, chosen from across schools in and around Chennai, says a press release.

The ceremony was graced by an eminent panel of guests and dignitaries. Film actor, motivational speaker and educa-

tionist Dhamu was chief guest. Founder of Farmguru Agritech was the guest of honour.

The event was also attended by Ushan Kumar Chordia, secretary; Hemant P. Chordia, associate secretary; N. Venkataramanan, director; M.M. Ramya, dean; and R. Surekha, deputy dean.

The ceremony featured a symbolic gesture of a student seeking blessings from a teacher, capturing the Guru-Shishya tradition.

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A photo contest for *the deaf*

The last date for submission of entries is September 30. The theme of the contest is nature conservation and the winners will be honoured during Wildlife Week 2026 in October

Rotary club of Chennai Crown and Madras photobloggers are organising an exclusive photo contest for the deaf on nature conservation, as part of International Week of Deaf Awareness. The link for submission is <http://tinyurl.com/YAAVARUM-PHOTO-CONTEST>. The last date for submission is September.

Winners of the contest will be honoured during Wildlife Week 2026 in October.

Earlier, on September 20, also as part of the International Week of Deaf Awareness, a nature photo walk was organised at Nanmangalam reserve forest exclusively for the deaf community, with interpreter support, through a collabora-

tive effort of Care Earth Trust, Tamil Nadu Forest Department, Madras Photobloggers, and Rotary Club of Chennai Crown.

Thirty-five deaf participants actively took part in the photowalk. Officials from Care Earth Trust and the Tamil Nadu Forest Department introduced participants to the rich

diversity of flora and fauna, helping them observe and appreciate the natural environment around them.

Rotary club of Chennai Crown and Madras photobloggers helped the participants in documenting nature, says a press release

Participants captured their ex-

periences through mobile phones and cameras, exploring nature through their own perspectives and creativity. The programme provided an inclusive space for the deaf community to connect with nature, learn about biodiversity, and express themselves through photography and the upcoming photocontest exclusively for the deaf.



City ophthalmologist honoured at conference in Bangkok

Ophthalmologist from Chennai Dr D P Prakash was invited to give a keynote speech on eye care at the United Nations Conference Centre in Bangkok on September 25. The summit was on sustainable living and wellbeing, says a press release.

His presentation was titled “The World- First Artificial Intelligence Based Vision Care System.”

In his address, the chief eye surgeon of American Eye Care Centre highlighted how India is losing a gross national income of 646 billion rupees due to the 70 million vision-impaired population apart from the 4.9 million blind people, says a press release.

He spoke a proprietary Agentic AI Technology known as “The Serranova” which would integrate every aspect of the vision testing process right from history to diagnosis and eye wear selection and referral, adds the press release.

The AI also generates what he calls “The Prakash Perfect Vision Score” that enables the patient to understand if his eyes are normal or not, says the press release.

Delegates from various member countries and dignitaries from WHO, Red Cross International and ambassadors to Thailand from Morocco, Nepal South Africa, Russia, and Hungary took part.

On the occasion, he received the Global Change Maker Award for his contribution towards advancing eye care and sustainable health care development from Dr . Giovanni Jing, UNESCO, Italy.

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